

Area of Study 2G – Sikhism

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Sikhism as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about the issues of peace and conflict, and crime and punishment.

There are four sections: Sikh Beliefs, Crime and Punishment, Living the Sikh Life and Peace and Conflict.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Sikhs today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how scripture informs a Sikh's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Sikhism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Sikhism with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.4)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.5)*

Students should recognise that Sikhism is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Sikhism and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Sikhism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Sikhism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Khalsa and non-Khalsa Sikhs.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of God: how the characteristics of God are shown in the Mool Mantar, Guru Granth Sahib 1, and why the characteristics are important and why the Mool Mantar is significant for Sikhs.
1.2	God as Creator: the nature and importance of God as Creator (Karta Purakh) for Sikhs; Sikh teachings on God as Creator, including Guru Granth Sahib 12 and 94.
1.3	The nature of human life: the purpose and significance of life as an opportunity to unite with God; Sikh understandings of why uniting with God is important; how uniting with God will affect their lives, including Guru Granth Sahib 12.
1.4*	Sikh beliefs about life after death: the nature of karma, rebirth and mukti (liberation); how they are shown in the Guru Granth Sahib, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 2, 11 and 78; divergent understandings of how and why karma, rebirth and mukti are important for Sikh life today.
1.5	Purpose of life: the nature and importance of being gurmukh (God-centred) not manmukh (self-centred) and the elimination of haumai (ego/pride), including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 125 and 226; what actions make a gurmukh Sikh; divergent understandings of why being gurmukh and eliminating haumai is important in Sikh life today.
1.6	The oneness of humanity: how the equality of all humans is shown in the Guru Granth Sahib, including Guru Granth Sahib 349; how equality is shown in stories from the lives of the Gurus, including the example of Mai Bhago and the appointment of women as teachers; and how equality is shown in Sikh life today; how and why complete equality of men and women is important for Sikhs today.
1.7	Sewa (service to others): the nature of sewa, including tan, man and dhan; the origins and purpose of sewa and its importance in the development of Sikhism, including Guru Granth Sahib 26; divergent understandings of the practice and importance of sewa in Sikh life today in reflecting the priority of service to others.
1.8	Sangat: the nature and history of the sangat; divergent understandings of why the sangat is important for Sikhs, including Guru Granth Sahib 1316; the concept of Sat Sangat and divergent understandings of its significance for Sikhs; problems for Sikhs living without a sangat.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Sikh attitudes towards justice: the nature of justice and why justice is important for Sikhs, including Guru Granth Sahib 274; Sikh responses to why justice is important for the victim; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why justice is important regardless of religion and belief and Sikh responses to these attitudes.
2.2	Sikh attitudes towards crime: Sikh teachings about and responses to the nature, causes and problem of crime, including avoiding the Five Thieves, with reference to Guru Granth Sahib 61; what action is taken by Sikh individuals and Sikh groups to end crime, including the Sikh Welfare Awareness Team (SWAT).
2.3	Sikh teachings about good, evil and suffering: Sikh teachings about the nature of good actions, how they are rewarded, and teachings about the nature of evil actions; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why people suffer, including believing in religion and Sikh responses to them, including Guru Granth Sahib 767; divergent Sikh teachings about why people suffer, including reference to human responsibility in Guru Granth Sahib 1062.
2.4	Sikh attitudes towards punishment: divergent Sikh teachings and attitudes to the nature and use of punishment, including reference to the Rahit Maryada Section 6 Chapter 8 Article XXV and links to situation ethics; Sikh teachings on why punishment can be regarded as justice and why punishment might be needed in society.
2.5	Sikh attitudes towards the aims of punishment: divergent Sikh attitudes towards each of the aims of punishment (protection, retribution, deterrence and reformation); Sikh teachings about punishment, including Guru Granth Sahib 148.
2.6	Sikh teachings about forgiveness: Sikh teachings and responses about the nature and importance of forgiveness; how offenders are forgiven by the community and why this is needed, including Guru Granth Sahib 1378; Sikh responses to the nature and use of restorative justice, and why it is important for criminals.
2.7	Sikh teachings about the treatment of criminals including the opportunity of reformation and the seeking of God in Guru Granth Sahib 245; divergent Sikh attitudes towards the use of torture, human rights, fair trial and trial by jury; the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, which may accept the use of torture if it is for the greater good.
2.8	Sikh attitudes towards the death penalty: the nature and purpose of capital punishment; divergent Sikh teachings about the nature, purpose and arguments surrounding the use of capital punishment, including interpretations of God's power of life and death in Guru Granth Sahib 7; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards the use of capital punishment, including the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, and Sikh responses to them.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	Features of the gurdwara: the nature, history and purpose of the design of the Gurdwara as the 'Door/Gate of the Guru', including Rahit Maryada Chapters 4–6; how and why objects of devotion are used within the gurdwara: Guru Granth Sahib, takht, chanani, chaur, the langar hall, four doors, and the Nishan Sahib; divergent understandings of the importance of these features in Sikh life today.
3.2	The gurdwara: the role and importance of the gurdwara within the Sikh community including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 1391; activities that take place within the gurdwara and why; the nature and importance of visiting Sikh historical gurdwaras: the Harmandir Sahib in Amritsar (the Golden Temple); divergent understandings of the importance of making such visits, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 4.
3.3	Langar: the history of langar including Guru Granth Sahib 967; the nature and purposes of langar; the significance of langar for Sikhs today, especially as an expression of sewa.
3.4	Nam Japna – meditating on the name of God: the nature and significance of Nam Japna; diverse ways in which the Nam Japna is used in the gurdwara and in Sikh daily life, including Guru Granth Sahib 1142.
3.5*	Prayer, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 305: the nature, role and purpose of prayer in the home; the different types of prayer; when prayer might take place and why; the importance of having different prayers.
3.6	Akhand path (continuous 48-hour reading of the Guru Granth Sahib): the nature, history, role and purpose of the akhand path including reference Rahit Maryada Chapter 7; how and why Sikhs might take part in the akhand path: why the akhand path is important for the Sikh community and for individual Sikhs.
3.7	Gurpurbs and commemorations: divergent understandings of the nature, history and purpose of gurpurbs and commemorations; why they are important for Sikhs today. The origins and meaning of gurpurbs, including Guru Nanak's birthday, Vaisakhi, including reference to the account of the events found in Gurbilas Patshahi 10. Divali: the origins and meaning of commemorations, including the martyrdom of Guru Arjan and Guru Tagh Bahadur Ji.
3.8	Birth and naming rituals and ceremonies: the celebration and significance of Naam Karan and Hukamnama; the significance of Amrit Sanskar (the initiation ceremony) for Sikh families, including reference to the Rahit Maryada Chapters 11 and 13; divergent understandings of these ceremonies between khalsa and non-khalsa Sikhs; the significance of the names Singh and Kaur in the naming and Amrit ceremonies, and for Sikh identity today.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Sikh attitudes towards peace: Sikh teachings about the nature and importance of peace, including Guru Granth Sahib 671; how these may be understood and applied differently in the life of a Sikh.
4.2	The role of Sikhs in peacemaking: Sikh teachings about peacemaking; the importance for Sikhs of justice, forgiveness and reconciliation in peacemaking; how Sikhs work for peace today, the divergent approaches in what they do and why they try to work for peace, including Guru Granth Sahib 599 and links to situation ethics.
4.3	Sikh attitudes to conflict: Sikh teachings and responses to the nature and causes of conflict; Sikh responses to the problems conflict causes within society, including Zafarnama 22 and links to situation ethics; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes about the role of religion in the causes of conflict and Sikh responses to them.
4.4	Sikh attitudes to pacifism: Sikh teachings and responses to the nature and history of pacifism, including the goal of peace in Guru Granth Sahib 831; Sikh teachings about passive resistance and examples of its use within Sikhism, including the Akali movement.
4.5	Sikh attitudes to the Just War theory: Sikh teachings and responses to the nature and importance of the Just War theory; the conditions of a Just War within Sikhism, with specific reference to Dharam Yudh, including Dasam Granth 1133; divergent opinions on whether a Just War is possible for Sikhs today, including the application of ethical theories such as situation ethics.
4.6	Sikh attitudes to Holy War: Sikh teachings about war and peace as shown in the Guru Granth Sahib; Sikh teachings about war with specific reference to the concept of the saint-soldier, including Bhai Nand's Tankah Nama, and teachings about not killing and when fighting is a person's duty; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards Holy War and Sikh responses to them.
4.7	Sikh attitudes to weapons of mass destruction (WMD): Sikh teaching and responses to the problems and benefits of WMD; Sikh attitudes towards the use of such weapons, including the possible damage to the earth and its importance in Guru Granth Sahib 146; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) and the application of ethical theories (such as utilitarianism) which support the acquisition of weapons of mass destruction, and Sikh responses to them.
4.8	Sikh responses to issues surrounding conflict: Sikh teachings and responses to the nature of problems involved in conflict – violence, war and terrorism, including links to the Five Thieves and Guru Granth Sahib 1330; how Sikhs have worked to overcome these issues; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) views towards the issues surrounding conflict and Sikh responses to them.